cinema buffs in particular will love identifying and dissecting. The approach, Motwane notes, "was to go fully Shakespearean" by amping up the drama, the set-up and the fun factor. Or, what Sabharwal calls capturing the "magic of Hindi cinema" and its myriad emotions—the song and dance, the tears, the laughter, the action. Nostalgia-tripping, though, wasn't going to suffice. Motwane and Sabharwal knew the audience would need compelling characters to root for. As much as the series is a homage to the creators and actors and an attempt to recognise the "statement and intent in the films" back then, says Motwane, the brief was to not make the cast imitate anyone. By casting actors with "no preconceived notions as to how they perform", the show benefits in making the characters' struggles relatable. Sidhant Gupta as a refugee who is an aspiring filmmaker and Ram Kapoor as a garrulous film financier in particular stand out. Depending on how *Jubilee* resonates and the conversations it generates, Motwane and Sabharwal are keen to continue their deep dive into the film industry and its evolution through multiple seasons. Sabharwal starts talking about the films of the 1960s referring to Manoj Kumar and the later work of Raj Kapoor, who is one of the many inspirations of the show. "Up until the early 2000s, there's great history, there's enough happening," he says. For now, though, the filmmakers await the audience's verdict. ■

Suhani Singh

BITE OF LOVE

Pratim Das Gupta's Netflix series ***Tooth Pari*** is about the improbable romance between a vampire and a dentist

Filmmaker Pratim Das Gupta knew he was sitting on a bloody good one-liner. What if a vampire broke her canine and visited a dentist and what if they eventually fell for each other? Yes, it is fatal attraction, but it is also a nifty premise. For really, when was the last time we saw vampires in Hindi cinema? *Bandh Darwaza*, a Ramsay horror flick from the 1990s, maybe?

Vampires are a mainstay in Hollywood, be it films (the *Twilight* series, or Dracula) or TV [*What We Do in the Shadows* (2019), *Vampire Diaries* (2009–2017)]. But in India, you rarely get to bite into them. Das Gupta isn't even drawn to the above-mentioned titles, but what he did love was how Park Chan-wook's *Thirst* (2009) and Tomas Alfredson's *Let the Right One In* (2008) "beautifully brought the concept [of vampires] into the mainstream". Das Gupta pitched his idea around, and filmmaker Sujoy Ghosh commented that it merited a film.

Das Gupta gets to go even longer with an eight-episode series set in Kolkata, which drops on April 20. In *Tooth Pari: When Love Bites*, the vampires reside in an underground space beneath a metro station. Only a few venture upstairs at night to feast, albeit without killing or infecting humans. Rumi (Tanya Maniktala) is one such daredevil whose loss of a tooth after a miscalculated hunt sets off a series of events, including a police officer (Sikander Kher) and a vampire hunter (Revathy) trying to track her brethren down. Tillotama Shome, Saswata Chatterjee, Adil Hussain and Shantanu Maheshwari as the haemophobic dentist round out the cast.

Das Gupta's earlier works—seven Bengali films—have all been set in the real world. With his first Hindi project and web series, his goal was to make the "amalgamation of the worlds feel real". "It is believable yet has a layer of fantasy," he says. "The vampires look and feel like us. It's just that they have a different diet." One way of achieving this was to shoot in actual locations. Barring a set built in Mumbai to show the wobbly world of vampires, most of the show unfolds in locations spread across North Kolkata.

In the Indian OTT space, *Tooth Pari* stands apart for its bizarre quotient, which includes 'cutmundus', an ageing legion of vampire hunters, who are seeking new, younger members. In its own idiosyncratic way, the show makes a case for coexistence and embracing the 'other'. Whether it finds an audience or not, Das Gupta is confident his show is already "a clutter breaker". Reason enough to give it a view. ■

Suhani Singh

With **Tooth Pari,** Pratim Das Gupta's aim is to make the amalgamation of the two worlds—real and fantasy— seem believable



PHANTOM LOVE
Tanya Maniktala and Shantanu Maheshwari in *Tooth Pari*